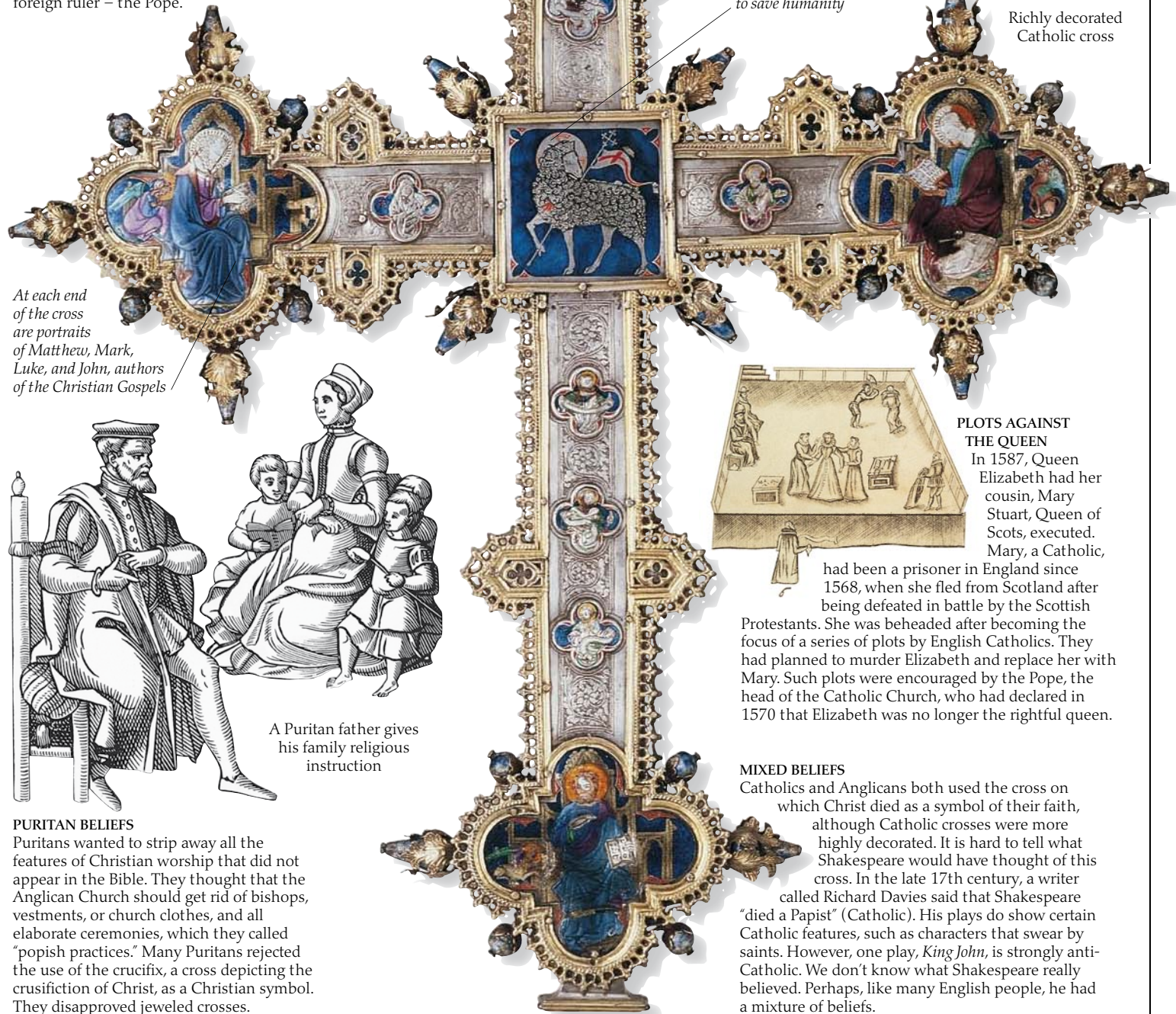




BLOODY MARY

Queen Mary had almost 290 Protestants burned at the stake, and fellow Protestants celebrated them as martyrs – heroes who died for their faith. The queen was nicknamed “Bloody Mary.” Elizabeth had 193 Catholics executed. They were killed not for their beliefs, but for treason, since they were loyal to a foreign ruler – the Pope.

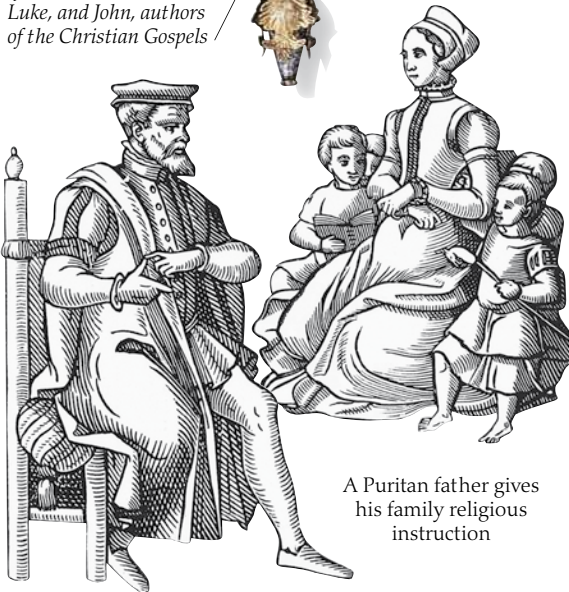


The lamb, a sacrificial animal, stands for Christ, whom Christians believe sacrificed himself to save humanity

Simple cross

Richly decorated Catholic cross

At each end of the cross are portraits of Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John, authors of the Christian Gospels



A Puritan father gives his family religious instruction

PURITAN BELIEFS

Puritans wanted to strip away all the features of Christian worship that did not appear in the Bible. They thought that the Anglican Church should get rid of bishops, vestments, or church clothes, and all elaborate ceremonies, which they called “popish practices.” Many Puritans rejected the use of the crucifix, a cross depicting the crucifixion of Christ, as a Christian symbol. They disapproved jeweled crosses.



PLOTS AGAINST THE QUEEN

In 1587, Queen Elizabeth had her cousin, Mary Stuart, Queen of Scots, executed. Mary, a Catholic, had been a prisoner in England since 1568, when she fled from Scotland after being defeated in battle by the Scottish Protestants. She was beheaded after becoming the focus of a series of plots by English Catholics. They had planned to murder Elizabeth and replace her with Mary. Such plots were encouraged by the Pope, the head of the Catholic Church, who had declared in 1570 that Elizabeth was no longer the rightful queen.

MIXED BELIEFS

Catholics and Anglicans both used the cross on which Christ died as a symbol of their faith, although Catholic crosses were more highly decorated. It is hard to tell what Shakespeare would have thought of this cross. In the late 17th century, a writer called Richard Davies said that Shakespeare “died a Papist” (Catholic). His plays do show certain Catholic features, such as characters that swear by saints. However, one play, *King John*, is strongly anti-Catholic. We don’t know what Shakespeare really believed. Perhaps, like many English people, he had a mixture of beliefs.